

Session 7: Murder and Contempt

Key Takeaways

- The command “do not murder” addresses the surface-level behavior. But God’s desire isn’t simply to keep us from killing others but for us to truly value others.
- The “valley” (Hebrew: *gey*) of Ben-hinnom, transliterated through Aramaic and Greek into the New Testament’s Gehenna, is the place where God returned the fiery horror of Israel’s idolatry back upon its leaders. It serves as an analogy for the way God will hold all of humanity accountable at the culmination of history.
- Jesus’ followers throughout the centuries have held to a diversity of interpretations about the meaning and nature of the final judgment described in the Bible.

“You Have Heard It Said ... ”

In these six teachings, Jesus first quotes from commands in the Torah, or alludes to popular teaching that is based on the Torah. The fact that he’s describing the Torah as it’s popularly taught is signaled by the phrase “You have heard ... ”

1. Matthew 5:21 **“You have heard that it was said to the ancients,** ‘Do not murder.’”
2. Matthew 5:27 **“You have heard that it was said,** ‘Do not commit adultery.’”
3. Matthew 5:31 **“And it has been said,** ‘Whoever divorces a woman must give her a certificate.’”
4. Matthew 5:33 **“Again, you have heard that it was said to the ancients,** ‘Don’t violate your oaths ...’”
5. Matthew 5:38 **“You have heard that it was said,** ‘An eye in place of an eye ...’”
6. Matthew 5:43 **“You have heard that it was said,** ‘Love your neighbor and hate your enemy.’”

After this, Jesus follows with an additional teaching with comments, always signaled by the same phrase:

- Greek: ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν
- English: “and/but I say to you ...”

What exactly this phrase signals has been a matter of debate. This is where interpreters have parted ways throughout history.

1. Antithesis: Jesus is offering a counter-teaching that supersedes the Torah. Translation: “but I say to you ...”
2. Agreement: Jesus agrees with the command as stated, and goes on to show what it looks like to follow this command faithfully. Translation: “and I say to you ...”
3. Fulfillment: Jesus agrees with the command as stated, but goes on to show how his “love God, love neighbor” ethic seeks to live by the unstated deeper values underneath the law, thus fulfilling the

command in a deeper way. The emphasis is on Jesus' unique take on the underlying divine purpose that motivates the command in the first place. Translation: "and I say to you ..."

David Daube, in his classic 1956 study of Jesus' teaching style in the context of early Rabbinic Judaism ([*The New Testament and Rabbinic Judaism*](#)), drew attention to a common style of biblical exposition in which two biblical texts were juxtaposed in a manner very similar to Jesus' six case studies here in Matthew 5.

""Honor your father and mother' - I have heard [= that it means] 'with words'. But instruction/Talmud says, it is written 'Honor *ha-shem* with your wealth' (Prov. 3:9). Just as there (in Proverbs) 'with wealth' so also here (in Exodus 20)."

Mekhilta of Rabbi Yishmael, on Exodus 20:12.

The phrase "I have heard" introduces a quotation from a biblical text that has been insufficiently understood. And so an additional biblical text is called in to show that "honor" means more than verbal affirmation, but sharing one's money.

"In Rabbinic discussion, *shome'a ani*, 'I hear,' or rather 'I understand,' introduces an interpretation of Scripture that, though conceivable, must be rejected as inadequate. ... The interpretation introduced by 'I hear,' is too narrow and literal compare with the interpretation accepted instead. ... There is good reason, then, for translating the first part of the Matthean form [of the case studies] by 'You have literally understood.' ... In other words, the phrase does not necessarily introduce a strict quotation, but a quotation provided with comment."

Adapted from Daube, David (1994). [*The New Testament and Rabbinic Judaism*](#). Hendrickson Pub. 55-56.

The phrase "But/and I say to you ..." is a common form used in rabbinic texts, where one biblical text is quoted according to a narrow or literal interpretation that is rejected, and the favored interpretation is introduced by the phrase "one says/you can say"

""And *Ha-Shem* descended upon Mount Sinai' - I have heard [= that it means] 'upon all of it.' But Talmud says 'upon the head of the mountain' [Exod. 20]"

Mekhilta of Rabbi Yishmael, on Exodus 19:20.

Case Study 1: Murder & Anger

- a 21 You have heard that **it was said** to the ancients,
 - b "You shall not commit **murder**,"
- a' and "Whoever commits **murder**
 - b' **will be guilty** by the **court**."

- a 22 **And I say** to you,

- b that everyone who is **angry** with **his brother**
 - c **will be guilty** by the **court** ;
- b' and whoever says to **his brother** , “ **You good-for-nothing** ,”
 - c' **will be guilty** by the **Sanhedrin** ;
- b'' and whoever says, “ **You fool** ,”
 - c'' **will be guilty** for the **gehenna of fire** .

- a 23 Therefore **if** you are **presenting your offering** at **the altar** ,
 - b and there remember that **your brother** has something against you,
- a' 24 leave **your offering** there before **the altar**
 - b' and go, first be reconciled to **your brother** ,
- c and **then** come and **present your offering**.

- 25 Settle matters in a friendly way with your **legal opponent** ,
while you are with him on the way,
- so that your **opponent** doesn't hand you over to the **court-judge** ,
and the **court-judge** to **the officer** ,
so you're thrown into **prison** .
- 26 Truly I say to you,
you will not come out of there
until you have paid up the last coin.

Matthew 5:21-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Jesus quotes the sixth of the Ten Commandments. He immediately affirms the validity of the command, and takes things to the next level, in a three-part stair-step riddle that increases the intensity of the command.

- Murder > anger > contemptuous insults
- “Good-for-nothing”: Greek *raqa'* = Aramaic ריקא “empty-one” [An Aramaic word spelled in Greek letters]
- “Fool”: Greek *moreh* [a Greek word]

Notice how the progression decreases in intensity of the action, but increases in the intensity of the consequences.

Decrease in intensity →			
Murder	Anger	“Good for nothing!”	“Fool!”
Guilty in court	Guilty in court	Guilty in Sanhedrin	Guilty in <i>gehenna</i>
Increase in intensity →			
<i>Intensity of Actions and Their Consequences.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).			

This is an excellent example of Jesus’ tongue-in-cheek style of hyperbole and overstatement, the purpose of which is to grab your attention and force you to think. By making the consequence for anger the same as the consequence for murder, he is not equating the two actions in terms of their social impact but in terms of their inner-source within the self. Jesus invites us to meditate on the deeper source of both murder and anger, which means focusing on our view of the worth and value of another’s life.

Jesus wants us to see that murder is the most extreme form of a much deeper reality that also expresses itself through name-calling: contempt for another that results in devaluing their life and dignity.

Contempt is underneath all of these forms of abuse. To show contempt through verbal abuse, through cultivation of angry resentment, or through violence or murder, these are all manifestations of the same core mindset.

To murder is to take up the role of God in deciding that this person has no value or that their life has no rightful place in our world. Angry contempt, and even flippant contempt, is a manifestation of the same mindset: To insult another human is to set oneself up as the evaluator of their dignity and worth.

Jesus, Murder, and the Torah

Jesus is not offering a counter-teaching to the Torah. (God said don’t murder, but I say it’s okay!)

“Jesus does not abolish, but rather shows the deepest sense and consummated reality of the commandment (= fulfillment). He gets to the heart of the matter by saying that the real issue underneath murder is not the act itself—and it is a wrong, devastating act—but the heart or inner disposition of the actor. ... Not committing the physical act of murder is good and right, but it is not the true litmus test of alignment with God’s will and coming kingdom. One must examine one’s attitudes and language about other people, which are just as important.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing](#). Baker Academic. 183.

Consider the progression of the three punishments.

1. “The court”: This must be a figure of speech, even humor, to sustain the parallel with [Matthew 5:21](#) that a murder trial is settled in civil court. How can anger be settled in a court trial?! By using the same

consequences (a court trial) for murder and anger, Jesus shows the equation of the two acts in terms of their deeper motive.

2. "The Sanhedrin": Here, Jesus intensifies the nature of the civil beyond that of a civil trial, and into the realm of the synagogues' religious court. The Sanhedrin refers either to a local synagogue's body of Torah authorities (as in [Matt. 10:17](#)) or to the ruling body of temple officials in Jerusalem ([Matt. 26:59](#)).
3. "The gehenna of fire": Here, the image shifts from a human court of evaluation to a divine court, which issues the sentence of "the gehenna of fire." "Gehenna" (Greek *τὴν γέενναν*) is a Greek transliteration of the Aramaic and Hebrew phrase, referring to a valley surrounding ancient (and modern) Jerusalem on its west and south sides.

The Gehenna of Fire

- Hebrew: *בֶּן־הִנּוֹם* (א) / *gey' ben hinnom*
- Aramaic: *גֵּיְהִנָּם* / *geyhinnam*
- Greek: *γέενναν* / *ge'enan*
- English: hell / gehenna

This valley is described as a feature around ancient Jerusalem.

Joshua 15:8 NASB

Then the border went up **the valley of Ben-hinnom** to the slope of the Jebusite on the south (that is, Jerusalem); and the border went up to the top of the mountain which is before the valley of Hinnom to the west, which is at the end of the valley of Rephaim toward the north.

Nehemiah 11:30 NASB

Zanoah, Adullam, and their villages, Lachish and its fields, Azekah and its towns. So they encamped from Beersheba as far as **the valley of Hinnom**.

In the later history of the Davidic monarchy that ruled in Jerusalem, this valley became the site of a number of altars on which Israelite children were sacrificed on fiery pyres, called *tophet* in Hebrew.

2 Chronicles 28:1-3 NASB

Ahaz was twenty years old when he became king, and he reigned sixteen years in Jerusalem; and he did not do right in the sight of the LORD as David his father had done.

But he walked in the ways of the kings of Israel; he also made molten images for the Baals.

Moreover, **he burned incense in the valley of Ben-hinnom** and burned his sons in fire, according to the abominations of the nations whom the LORD had driven out before the sons of Israel.

2 Chronicles 33:1-6 NASB

¹ **Manasseh** was twelve years old when he became king, and he reigned fifty-five years in Jerusalem.

² He did evil in the sight of the LORD according to the abominations of the nations whom the LORD dispossessed before the sons of Israel.

³ For he rebuilt the high places which Hezekiah his father had broken down; he also erected altars for the Baals and made Asherim, and worshiped all the host of heaven and served them.

⁴ He built altars in the house of the LORD of which the LORD had said, "My name shall be in Jerusalem

forever.”

⁵ For he built altars for all the host of heaven in the two courts of the house of the LORD.

⁶ **He made his sons pass through the fire in the valley of Ben-hinnom;** and he practiced witchcraft, used divination, practiced sorcery and dealt with mediums and spiritists. He did much evil in the sight of the LORD, provoking him to anger.

Josiah’s reforms in Jerusalem were enacted in order to defile the site so that it could no longer be used.

2 Kings 23:10 NASB

He also defiled Topheth, which is in **the valley of the son of Hinnom**, that no man might make his son or his daughter pass through the fire for Molech.

2 Kings 23:13–14 NASB

The high places which were before Jerusalem, which were on the right of the mount of destruction which Solomon the king of Israel had built for Ashtoreth the abomination of the Sidonians, and for Chemosh the abomination of Moab, and for Milcom the abomination of the sons of Ammon, the king defiled.

He broke in pieces the sacred pillars and cut down the Asherim and filled their places with human bones.

After Josiah’s reforms, his successors revived the ritual slaughter of children in the valley of Hinnom, and so Jeremiah railed against them, announcing a reversal and doom for the city and the valley.

Jeremiah 7:30–33 NASB

“For the sons of Judah have done that which is evil in my sight,” declares the LORD,

“they have set their detestable things in the house which is called by my name, to defile it.

They have built **the high places of Topheth,**

which is in **the valley of the son of Hinnom,**

to burn their sons and their daughters in the fire,

which I did not command, and it did not come into my mind.

Therefore, behold, days are coming,” declares the LORD,

“when it will no longer be called **Topheth,**

or **the valley of the son of Hinnom,**

but **the valley of the Slaughter;**

for they will bury in **Topheth** because there is no other place.

The dead bodies of this people will be food for the birds of the sky and for the beasts of the earth; and no one will frighten them away.”

Jeremiah 19:2–6 NASB

² Then go out to **the valley of Ben-hinnom**, which is by the entrance of the potsherd gate, and proclaim there the words that I tell you,

³ and say, “Hear the word of the LORD, O kings of Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem: thus says the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel,

‘Behold I am about to bring a calamity upon this place, at which the ears of everyone that hears of it will tingle.

⁴ Because they have forsaken me and have made this an alien place

and have burned sacrifices in it to other gods,

that neither they nor their forefathers nor the kings of Judah had ever known,

and because they have filled this place with the blood of the innocent

⁵ and have built the high places of Baal

to burn their sons in the fire as burnt offerings to Baal,

a thing which I never commanded or spoke of, nor did it ever enter my mind;

⁶ therefore, behold, days are coming,' declares the LORD,

'when this place will no longer be called **Topheth or the valley of Ben-hinnom,**

but rather **the valley of Slaughter.**'"

Jeremiah 32:33–35 NASB

[The sons of Israel] have turned their back to me and not their face; though I taught them, teaching again and again, they would not listen and receive instruction.

But they put their detestable things in the house which is called by my name, to defile it.

They built the high places of Baal that are **in the valley of Ben-hinnom to cause their sons and their daughters to pass through the fire to Molech**, which I had not commanded them nor had it entered my mind that they should do this abomination, to cause Judah to sin.

The imagery of fiery altars consuming children offered in sacrifice represents the height of Israel's heinous violation of their covenant with Yahweh. And so Yahweh will reverse the entire situation, so that the valley of Hinnom will become a place of fiery death for the Israelites who perpetrated these crimes against children.

Notice the inversion role that this valley plays.

- The fires that these leaders started to consume the innocent ...
- ... will one day be turned back to consume those leaders.

The image of a valley filled with the corpses of those who die in the coming Babylonian siege is described in 7:32-34. The fire-altar (*topheth*) that Israel lit to burn their children will now be the place where animals consume them. The idea of unburied corpses is revolting in light of the purity practices of ancient Judaism.

Important side note: It is often repeated in older commentaries that Gehenna was a trash dump where garbage was incinerated. There is, however, no ancient evidence that ever states this.

"The standard view, namely, that the valley was where the city's garbage was incinerated and that the constantly rising smoke and smell of corruption conjured up the fiery torments of the damned, is without ancient support. ... Perhaps the abode of the wicked dead gained its name because children had there been sacrificed in fire to the god Molech (2 Chr. 28:3; 33:6), or because Jeremiah, recalling its defilement by Josiah (2 Kgs. 23:10; cf. 21:6), thundered against the place (Jer. 7:31-32; 19:2-9; 32:35), or because it was believed that in the valley was the entrance to the underworld home of the pagan chthonian deities (cf. b. 'Erub. 19a)."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 515.

This imagery is metaphorically developed in Isaiah, in portrayals of God's ultimate act of justice that will purge the wicked from the new Jerusalem/new creation.

Isaiah 1:27–31 NASB

Zion will be redeemed with justice and her repentant ones with righteousness.

But transgressors and sinners will be crushed together, and those who forsake the LORD will come to an end.

Surely you will be ashamed of the oaks which you have desired, and you will be embarrassed at the gardens which you have chosen.

For you will be like an oak whose leaf fades away or as a garden that has no water.

The strong man will become tinder, his work also a spark. Thus they shall both burn together and there will be none to quench them.

Isaiah 66:15–17 NASB

“For behold, **the LORD will come in fire**

and his chariots like the whirlwind,

to render his anger with fury,

and his rebuke **with flames of fire.**

For the LORD will execute judgment **by fire**

and by his sword on all flesh,

and those slain by the LORD will be many.

Those who sanctify and purify themselves to go to the gardens,

following one in the middle,

who eat swine’s flesh, detestable things and mice,

will come to an end altogether,” declares the LORD.

Isaiah 66:22–24 NASB

“For just as the new heavens and the new earth

which I make will endure before me,” declares the LORD,

“so your offspring and your name will endure.

And it shall be from new moon to new moon

and from sabbath to sabbath,

all mankind will come to bow down before me,” says the LORD.

“Then they will go forth and look

on the corpses of the men

who have transgressed against me.

For their worm will not die

and their fire will not be quenched;

and they will be an abhorrence to all mankind.”

Whether Jesus took this divine fire of justice to be a (a) cause of eternal conscious torment or (b) destructive agent that brings a creature’s existence to an end or (c) purging experience that removes evil and restores a creature to purity, this is a matter worth studying in greater detail. However, for the moment, it’s sufficient to say that in Jesus’ teachings, it represents the ultimate moment of divine justice on human and spiritual evil.

Two Parables

1. Parable #1: Matthew 5:23-24—Worship and one’s brother

This is related by the link-word “brother,” who received the anger and insults of Jesus’ earlier statement. This parable assumes that the “you offering your gift” has gotten angry with and insulted his “brother.” Jesus emphasizes that if you have treated another person with contempt, your strained relationship with them horizontally is matched by a strained relationship vertically, with God.

This parable is absolutely designed to echo the story of Cain and Abel in Genesis 4: Brothers are offering gifts on the altar. One brother gets angry and “wrongs” (murders) his brother.

The health and quality of my relationship with God is directly connected to the health and quality of my relationships with people. If my relationships with people are unhealthy, my relationship with God is unhealthy.

2. Parable #2: Matthew 5:25-26

This parable picks up the link-word “court/judge” imagery from Matthew 5:22. The parable is about settling a legal dispute (in which you are the accused): If you’re guilty, do whatever it takes to settle the matter, because you don’t want to face the court in your current, guilty status.

Reflection Question

How does Jesus’ teaching in Matthew 5:21-26 deepen the commandment to not murder?